

Sentinel Event Management and Root Cause Analysis

Policy Number	POL-RM-004	Owner / Department	Risk Management / Patient Safety
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Approved By	Patient Safety & Quality Committee	Applies To	All departments; coordinated by Risk Management and the Patient Safety Officer

1. Purpose

To define the facility's response to sentinel events and Serious Reportable Events, including immediate stabilization, a comprehensive systematic analysis (RCA²), and a measurable corrective action plan.

2. Definitions

- **Sentinel event** — a patient-safety event not primarily related to the natural course of the patient's illness that reaches the patient and results in death, permanent harm, or severe temporary harm.
- **Severe temporary harm** — critical, potentially life-threatening harm lasting a limited time with no permanent residual, but requiring transfer to a higher level of care, additional major surgery/procedure, or life-sustaining intervention.
- **Serious Reportable Event** — an NQF "never event"; always managed as a sentinel-level event.

3. Immediate Response

IMPORTANT — A sentinel event is always SEV-1. Notify the Administrator-on-Call, Risk Management, and the Patient Safety Officer immediately. Secure and sequester any involved equipment, devices, medications, and packaging — do not discard, clean, or return to service — and preserve them for analysis.

1. Stabilize the patient and meet immediate care needs.
2. Notify Risk Management and the Administrator-on-Call immediately (within 1 hour).
3. Sequester devices, medications, and records; document chain of custody.
4. Begin disclosure to the patient/family per the disclosure policy.
5. Provide support to involved staff (second-victim resources).

4. Comprehensive Systematic Analysis (RCA²)

- Risk Management convenes an interdisciplinary RCA² team within 72 hours of the event.
- The analysis must be thorough and credible: identify root causes and contributing factors, focusing on systems and processes rather than individual blame.

- A corrective action plan — specific, measurable, time-limited, with assigned owners — and the completed analysis are finalized within 45 business days of the event or of becoming aware of it.
- Action items are tracked to closure with effectiveness measures.

5. External Reporting

Risk Management determines and coordinates any external reporting (The Joint Commission self-report, State Department of Health, CMS). Self-reporting to The Joint Commission is voluntary; the comprehensive systematic analysis is completed regardless of whether the event is reported externally.

6. References

- The Joint Commission, Sentinel Event Policy and Procedures.
- National Patient Safety Foundation, RCA² — Improving Root Cause Analyses and Actions to Prevent Harm.
- National Quality Forum, Serious Reportable Events.
- Related: POL-RM-013 (severity & reporting).